Sangram, writes one admiring historian, was ‘deadly as the darts of fate’, and Akbar’s aim was true. He fired, then turned to the two men by his side, Shajaat Khan and Bhagwant Das (brother of Akbar’s wife Harkha Bai). He had felt the ‘pleasure and lightness of hand’ that he often experienced when he knew his shot had struck home. He knew that ‘he had hit the man’.[38]

A little later, the men guarding the breach disappeared. They had left kindling in the gaps unlit; instead, the Mughals noticed small fires coming alight deep within the fort. It was Bhagwant Das who told them what the flames signified. Jauhar. The Rajputs were burning their wives and mothers and daughters alive, and preparing for their very last fight.

The man with the spiked breastplate, his form lit by gunfire, shot down by Sangram, was none other than Jaimal, commander-in-chief of Chittorgarh. When Jaimal fell, the fortress fell with him. Some 8000 Rajputs – Sisodiyas, Rathaurs, Chauhans – lit funeral pyres, burned 300 women, and prepared themselves to die.

‘At the white dawn’, the Mughal army poured into the fort – along with many war elephants, whose feats, often enough, get more space than those of soldiers in Akbar’s chronicles.[39] One Jangiya, for example, had his trunk cut off by a Rajput’s blade, which ‘makes life difficult’, as Abul Fazl admits. Still, Jangiya killed another fifteen men, on top of the thirty he had already slain, before he died. Another, Madhukar, seems to have killed the Chauhan chief, Isar Das, as he grabbed the animal by a tusk and stabbed him with his dagger.

Akbar rode ‘an elephant, majestic as heaven’, through the bloodied streets of Chittor, watching its final battle.[40] ‘In every street and lane and bazar,’ one historian writes, ‘there was desperate fighting.’[41] By the end of the day, all the Rajput soldiers had fallen to Mughal shafts, blades and spears, or taken their own lives, preferring death to disgrace.

Among the scenes that Akbar would recall, years later, was that of an anonymous Mughal soldier refusing his friend’s help in hand-to-hand combat with a Rajput, declaring that it was against ‘the rules of chivalry and courage’ to offer such aid. Later, the padishah looked for the ‘brave . . . man’, but he was nowhere to be found – perhaps he was an apparition, Abul Fazl muses, come ‘to help’ the emperor.

How he was meant to help is not clear, for Akbar did not follow his